

ENGLISH TAKES CENTRESTAGE

A new generation of playwrights is waiting in the wings to make it big. And, this time the curtain is rising on English, the language young and urbane India speaks and understands.



AJAY KRISHNAN, 22.
His play *Butter and Mashed Banana* won five awards at the Thespo Youth Theatre Festival.

■ **By Nirmala Ravindran**

Last year, actor Kamal Haasan was the chief guest at the inauguration of a film festival in Thiruvananthapuram. After speaking two sentences in Malayalam, he announced with a flourish, "And now I hope you will excuse me for switching from Malayalam to English, the national language of India." Haasan was only reinstating an already accepted fact: English is probably the most important medium of expression for young India, nowhere highlighted more than in the emergence of a new breed of desi playwrights writing only in English.

Denounced till recently as 'artificial', with put-on British accents not suited to the Indian stage, the English language is now being looked upon as the single most unifying element of the new generation of writers. The plays staged earlier this year at the Writer's Bloc Festival held in Mumbai by the Royal Court Theatre (RCT), London, in association with Rage Theatre Productions, explain the phenomenon best. Swar Thounaojam, 26, who wrote the play *Turel* in English was one of the most applauded playwrights at the festival—and she was not alone. The English applicants in the Writer's Block workshop which preceded the festival,

numbered more than a hundred, compared to a handful of Indian language entries. "We manage to get a few plays in Hindi and Marathi, and maybe one or two in Bangla and Tamil, while the English entries pour in," says actor-director Shernaz Patel of Rage Productions.

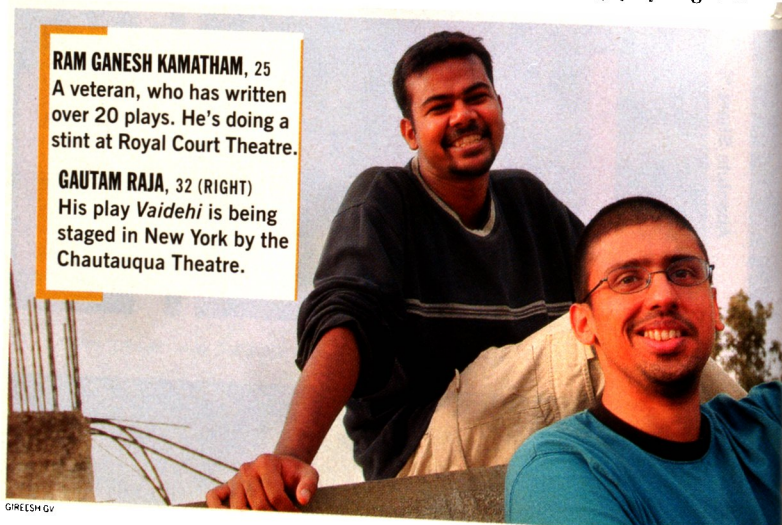
The festival has proved to be a shot in the arm for many young playwrights not only because of the mentorship that

it guarantees with Carl Miller and Phyllida Lloyd—both RCT playwrights—but also because it assures them that the plays they write will be produced and performed at the end of the workshop. For instance, 25-year-old Ram Ganesh Kamatham who wrote *Crab*, a searing tale of the urban young and their negotiations in an alien landscape, is now a writer-in-residence at RCT, allowing him to quit a lucrative career in a software company to write plays in English.

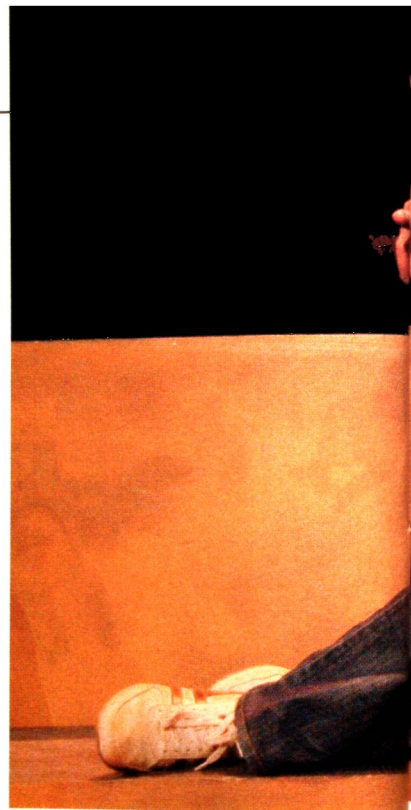
Another promising playwright is

RAM GANESH KAMATHAM, 25
A veteran, who has written over 20 plays. He's doing a stint at Royal Court Theatre.

GAUTAM RAJA, 32 (RIGHT)
His play *Vaidehi* is being staged in New York by the Chautauqua Theatre.



GIREESH GV



AMEET MALLAPUR